

The National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of

1976-12-02 • UHG • Nationale Geistige Räte

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1976-12-02

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

182.1 Your letter of 12 October 1976 proposing the establishment of an International Human Development Center has caused us concern for a number of reasons. It is true that in our letter of 23 December 1975 we stated: "We feel that it is for your Assembly to decide what methods should be employed to bring about the desired result," but your present proposals are a great enlargement and development of the concepts outlined in your letter of 5 December 1975 and involve the establishment of an institution with international ramifications requiring financial assistance from beyond the confines of your own community.

269182.2 We are acutely aware of the varied problems of community and character development that the American Bahá'í community faces. They are problems that in varying ways and to different degrees face every Bahá'í community in the world. In many countries they are further complicated by grinding poverty, widespread illiteracy, religious persecution or compulsory political indoctrination.

182.3 As you quite correctly observe, Bahá'í Administration should make use of whatever expertise or appropriate instruments are available, whether Bahá'í or non-Bahá'í, for the attainment of its objectives. But this is not the same as establishing a quasi-Bahá'í institution under Bahá'í auspices based on one particular theory. It is far too early in the development of the Faith and of the social sciences for the Administrative Order thus to promote one particular system or theory of education. A similar situation exists in the field of psychology. As you are well aware, many people come into the Faith needing psychiatric treatment, and it is often very difficult for them to find a psychiatrist who will not urge them to some course of behavior which is contrary to the teachings of the Faith. There are a number of Bahá'í psychologists and psychiatrists who are endeavoring to develop their skills in the light of the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh, and use can certainly be made of their services where available—but it would be premature to consider establishing a Bahá'í School of Psychology

The Gradual Unfoldment of Bahá'í Education 182.4 The grave problems faced by Bahá'í parents and children, when the children must attend schools that are strongly influenced by the degradation of present-day society, are fully appreciated. However, the only ways to completely overcome these dangers would seem to be either to effect a reform of the entire non-Bahá'í educational system or to provide a worldwide network of Bahá'í schools. Both ways are very long-term projects beyond the capacity of the Bahá'í community at this time. Already, of course, Bahá'í communities are establishing primary or tutorial schools in many parts of the world, but these are small and few in number and are located where there are such conditions as general illiteracy among the believers or where no other schools are available to them. Undoubtedly, in time, this process will gain momentum, and Bahá'í schools of ever higher quality and scope will be established in country after country, as has already occurred in India, but necessarily, this must now be a gradual process related, among other things, to the resources of the community, the number of Bahá'í children needing education, and the availability of other suitable schools. Perhaps in certain parts of the United States there are sufficiently large concentrations of Bahá'í children to make the running of a private Bahá'í school feasible—such a proposal has, indeed, been made by a number of individual believers in Alaska, principally teachers, but we stressed in that instance that, if implemented, it should be conducted as

a private venture and that the people concerned should give very careful consideration to all the factors involved before initiating it; furthermore we pointed out to them their opportunities for improving the schools in which they themselves worked.

182.5 Failing a nationwide system of Bahá'í schools, the establishment of which is clearly out of the question at this stage of the growth of the Cause in the United States, Bahá'í parents will continue to be faced with the problems caused by the exposure of their children to irreligious and immoral attitudes, behavior, and even instruction, from their fellow pupils and their teachers. This is a great challenge to Bahá'í parents, to the Bahá'í children themselves, and to the Spiritual Assemblies. It was to assist in meeting such challenges that we recently issued the compilation of Bahá'í prayers for children and that on Bahá'í education. Your Assembly is correct in its view that a major effort will have to be exerted to raise the number and quality of Bahá'í children's classes, and to assist Bahá'í parents to bring up their children as firm Bahá'ís able to withstand the moral and spiritual poisons and temptations of the society around them.... The Spiritual Nature of Personal Transformation 182.6 In addition to the specific problems of child education, you instance the difficulties of local communities which are faced with the task of reorienting and integrating into the Cause new believers who enter with all sorts of immoral and even criminal tendencies from their former life. This is indeed difficult, but this is the very stuff of the work of the Cause. The Bahá'í Faith not only provides teachings in accordance with which the behavior of human beings can be reformed, but also makes available a spiritual power which reinforces the devoted efforts of every believer, whether veteran or neophyte. Arising to serve the Cause has, itself, a transforming effect upon believers, as the beloved Guardian wrote with respect to service upon Spiritual Assemblies: "If we but turn our gaze to the high qualifications of the members of Bahá'í Assemblies, as enumerated in 'Abdu'l-Bahá's Tablets, we are filled with feelings of unworthiness and dismay, and would feel truly disheartened but for the comforting thought that if we arise to play nobly our part every deficiency in our lives will be more than compensated by the all-conquering spirit of His grace and power." Thus, what is most imperative for the promotion of the spiritual life of local Bahá'í communities is the stimulation of the believers to increase their devotion to Bahá'u'lláh, their absolute reliance upon Him and upon His love, and their determination to apply His teachings in every aspect of their lives. This stimulation can be conveyed from heart to heart and mind to mind by devoted Bahá'ís without the need of formal training....

The Auxiliary Board: A Potent Aid to Consultation 182.7 As we pointed out previously, you have already initiated excellent programs; we continually receive evidence of the enthusiasm with which they have been received by local communities in the United States. You should persevere with these programs, expanding and supplementing them as necessary with others that you may judge desirable for the work of the Cause in the conditions of each of the widely diverse areas of your vast national territory. One of the most potent aids to the consolidation of local communities and Assemblies and the deepening of the faith of the believers, is the services of the Auxiliary Board members and their assistants. Here is an institution of the Faith, reaching into every locality, composed of firm believers who know the area they have to serve and are familiar with its problems and potentialities—an institution expressly designed to encourage and reinforce the work of the Spiritual Assemblies, to enthuse the believers, to stimulate them to study the Teachings and apply them in their lives—a body of Bahá'ís whose efforts and services will complement and support the work being done by your committees and by the Local Assemblies themselves in every sphere of Bahá'í endeavor.... With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

271183 Call For a Vigorous Traveling Teaching Program

19 DECEMBER 1976

To all National Spiritual Assemblies Dear Bahá'í Friends, 183.1 Now that we have passed the midway point of the Five Year Plan and through the grace of the Blessed Beauty the processes which it has set in motion in every continent are gaining momentum, we observe almost daily with awe and admiration how abundant are the blessings which surround the efforts of the devoted believers who are delivering His divine Message with dedication, enthusiasm and perseverance, and how infinitely vast and challenging are the possibilities for the future.

183.2 One of the activities which must be given greater attention, both nationally and internationally, is travel teaching to localities which are in need of consolidation and stimulation. While teaching projects of short duration, in terms of days and one or two weeks, are useful, the time has come for long-term teaching projects of three to six months and possibly more, as envisaged in the Five Year Plan, to be more vigorously prosecuted in every continent, so that more lasting results may accrue from these teaching trips and the rich harvest anticipated at the outset of the Plan may become a reality, imparting its inestimable benefits to the devoted laborers in His divine Vineyard.

183.3 It is hoped that those who will arise will be mostly self-supporting or supported by private deputization, and that the funds of the Faith, nationally for projects on the homefront, and internationally for projects in foreign fields, will be requested only when the individual concerned is regarded as well qualified and there is no other source of funds available to him. 183.4 We hope that National Assemblies whose assignments include international travel teaching projects will make a special appeal to the friends under their jurisdiction calling on them to meet this new challenge. If this urgent call, which is directed to all believers in every land, is answered with promptness and enthusiasm by those whose personal circumstances permit, great advances will be made towards fulfilling the hitherto sorely neglected teaching goals of the Plan. While the youth can through their creative resourcefulness and energetic labors effectively support the work ahead, believers from the older age groups can be a valuable asset in the achievement of the goals through their experience, knowledge and wisdom.

183.5 Our prayers are offered frequently at the Holy Shrines for the infinite blessings of the Abhá Beauty to reinforce every step you take in strengthening and broadening the foundations of the Faith in the areas entrusted to your care.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

272184 Message to the International Teaching Conference, Auckland, New Zealand—January 1977

JANUARY 1977

To the Friends assembled at the International Teaching Conference in Auckland Dearly loved Friends, 184.1 With hearts full of love and admiration for the followers of the Most Great Name in Australasia we send our warmest greetings to all assembled in this historic gathering in the heart of the Antipodes.

184.2 How great is your place in Bahá'í history! How bright are the prospects for the future of the Cause so lovingly nurtured for more than half a century by hundreds of stalwart steadfast believers, spiritual heirs of Hyde and Clara Dunn, who in direct response to the Tablets of the Divine Plan forsook their home and went to pioneer in Australia, and whose names, Shoghi Effendi wrote, were “graven in letters of gold” upon his heart. In March 1951, when in the entire Pacific area there was but one National Spiritual Assembly, the beloved Guardian predicted that “The prizes destined for the heroic warriors, battling for the Cause of Bahá'u'lláh throughout the Southern Hemisphere, and particularly Australasia, are glorious beyond compare. The assistance to be vouchsafed to them from on high in their struggle for its establishment, its recognition and triumph is ready to be poured forth in astonishing abundance.”

184.3 Now, twenty-five years later, the achievements are truly astounding. Beginning with the establishment of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of New Zealand at Rí ḡvân 1957, the number of National Assemblies has increased elevenfold; the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár of the Antipodes has been erected near Sydney; His Highness Malietoa Tanumafili II of Western Samoa has become the first reigning monarch to embrace the Cause of Bahá'u'lláh; the number of Local Spiritual Assemblies now stands at over 360; and the number of localities where Bahá'ís reside in this vast oceanic area covering well-nigh one-eighth of the earth's surface is more than 1,800. These accomplishments doubtless have been a source of great joy to the immortal soul of Shoghi Effendi, whose esteem and affection for the followers of Bahá'u'lláh laboring for His Cause in the Antipodes was frequently expressed in glowing terms in his letters to the Assemblies and friends in Australasia.

184.4 Dear friends, we have now passed the midpoint of the Five Year Plan. You are met in the beautiful city of Auckland to take stock and to make plans for attaining the victories which will surely be yours.

184.5 The National Spiritual Assemblies of the New Hebrides and of the Marshall Islands are to be raised up next Rí ḡvân; plans for the soon-to-be-erected Mashriqu'l-Adhkár of Samoa are in process; but although the goal of establishing Bahá'í centers totalling 2,188 is within easy reach, the Local Assembly goals assigned to each national community, totalling 613, need prompt and decisive attention. The divine assistance spoken of by the beloved Guardian in 1951 has ever been available, and is still “ready to be poured forth in astonishing abundance.” It is within your power during the coming year to win all assigned teaching goals, leaving the final year of the Plan for consolidation and the winning of supplementary victories.

273184.6 This will be achieved, not by resting on laurels, but by manifesting those qualities of faith, judgement, vision, loyalty, courage and self-sacrifice which earned the Guardian's praise so frequently in past decades. Let the valiant Australasian Bahá'í communities vie once more with their sister communities throughout the world for the palm of victory and maintain their position in the vanguard of the Army of Light.

184.7 Pioneers, traveling teachers and a fresh outpouring of funds are essential ingredients to the onward march of the Cause throughout Australia, New Zealand and the islands of the South Pacific. Let those who can offer their valued services to the teaching work arise without delay; let those who cannot travel or pioneer deputize those who can go in their stead. 184.8 We cherish the highest hopes for the success of your endeavors and it is our constant prayer that Bahá'u'lláh will shower His richest blessings and confirmations upon you. THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

185 Message to the International Teaching Conference, Bahia, Brazil—January 1977

JANUARY 1977

To the Followers of Bahá'u'lláh gathered at the International Teaching Conference in Bahia, Brazil Dearly loved Friends, 185.1 With joyous hearts we hail the convocation of this first of the twin Latin American Conferences closing the series of eight International Bahá'í Conferences held during the midway period of the Five Year Plan.

185.2 The ringing call of Bahá'u'lláh in His Most Holy Book to the Rulers of America and the Presidents of the Republics therein was followed after an interval of more than four decades by the revelation of ‘Abdu'l-Bahá's Tablets of the Divine Plan in which the beloved Master stressed the importance of the Republics of the South American Continent.

185.3 The first believer to respond to ‘Abdu'l-Bahá's divine call was that star-servant of the Cause of Bahá'u'lláh, valiant, indomitable Martha Root, who in 1919 visited many important cities in South America. Two years later Leonora Holsapple Armstrong, mother of the Bahá'ís of Brazil, settled in Bahia. The

teaching work in the continent progressed steadily to the point where, in 1937, the beloved Guardian launched his first Seven Year Plan paving the way for the raising in subsequent Plans of the institution of Bahá'u'lláh Administrative Order in every one of its republics and in its islands. It was in the course of that first Seven Year Plan that 'Abdu'l-Bahá's beloved handmaid, May Maxwell, in 1940 won a martyr's crown when she laid down her life in Argentina, thereby adding further lustre to the spiritual history of South America. 185.4 How truly fitting, then, that this auspicious Conference have its venue in the city of Bahia, singled out for special mention by 'Abdu'l-Bahá in His Tablets of the Divine Plan. And how timely it is at this crucial point in the Five Year Plan that the friends gathered in Bahia from 274 many lands prayerfully consider, and arise to prosecute expeditiously all measures aimed at achieving glorious victory in all goals of the Plan.

185.5 Noteworthy progress has been achieved in many fields of service throughout the South American Bahá'í community, particularly in attracting to the Cause large numbers of its indigenous peoples. But myriads of pure-hearted souls have not yet heard the clarion call of Bahá'u'lláh and hungrily await the spiritual nourishment that only His followers can give them. 185.6 Steps must be taken to attract members of every stratum of society to the divine circle of the Faith through effective proclamation and teaching. Greater utilization of radio broadcasts is necessary, not only to reach all levels of society but also to deepen the believers themselves. The valuable and dynamic services of Bahá'í youth must be multiplied in the fields of pioneering and travel teaching. A far wider dissemination of Bahá'í literature must be accompanied by a continuous program of translation of the Sacred Text into the major indigenous languages of the continent.

185.7 The continental goals for South America of 8,670 centers and 2,293 Local Spiritual Assemblies must be won, and may even be surpassed, for every country must achieve the goals assigned to it. This calls for the dedicated effort of every National Spiritual Assembly, every Local Spiritual Assembly and indeed every believer. All the divinely ordained instruments of the Administrative Order of Bahá'u'lláh must now unite in executing a symphony of victory in all the unfinished goals of the Five Year Plan, winning thereby the good pleasure of the Blessed Beauty.

185.8 Beloved friends, go forward with complete assurance that a continent so rich in spiritual promise, so diverse in its peoples and races, so fertile for the planting of the seeds of Bahá'u'lláh's Faith will yield a brilliant harvest for all who labor in that Divine Vineyard. 185.9 It is our fervent loving prayer at the Sacred Threshold that Bahá'u'lláh's bountiful confirmations and richest blessings may be showered upon you.

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

186 Signature of Contract for Erection

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]